This vegetable and lentil dish is best served piping hot, in cavernous bowls. You can find pink lentils (*masoor dal*) in most Asian food stores.

kichidi

SERVES 6–8 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 50 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
AT THE END OF STEP 3

1 butternut squash, about 1lb 9oz (700g)
½ tsp garam masala
salt and pepper
2 tbsp olive oil
3½oz (100g) basmati rice
3½oz (100g) pink or red lentils
2in (5cm) ginger, peeled and finely grated
2 tbsp ghee or clarified butter
2 tsp cumin seeds
½ tsp crushed hot red pepper flakes
juice of 1 lime
3 tbsp chopped cilantro
2 tbsp unsalted butter

1 Preheat the oven to 400°F (200°C). Halve the squash lengthwise and scoop out the seeds and fibers. Put it in a roasting pan, cut side up, sprinkle with the garam masala, season with salt and pepper, and drizzle with the oil. Cover with foil and roast for 45 minutes, or until meltingly tender. Let cool slightly, then scoop out the flesh, lightly crush it with a fork, and set aside.

2 Meanwhile, combine the rice and lentils in a large saucepan and cover with 2 quarts (2 liters) of water. Add the ginger, bring to a boil, then reduce the heat and simmer for about 30 minutes until the rice grains have lost their texture and broken down. Add more hot water to loosen the texture, if desired. Stir in the lightly crushed squash.

3 Heat the ghee in a separate pan and cook the cumin and red pepper flakes for about 30 seconds, until aromatic and darker in color. Tip the spices and ghee into the rice and lentils and stir well, seasoning with plenty more salt and pepper.

4 Stir in the lime juice and cilantro. Divide between deep bowls and finish with a generous dollop of butter in the center of each helping.